INSIGHTS | Commentary

Our Biggest Stories of 2025: From Climate Politics to AI and Beyond

WRI rounded up 15 of our biggest stories from 2025, covering everything from extreme heat and wildfires to climate politics, AI and beyond.

By: Maggie Overholt and **Sarah Parsons**

December 17, 2025

Explore More: Climate | climate change | International Climate Action | extreme heat | fires | Clean Energy | transportation | adaptation | restoration | development | data visualization



Image by Eduardo Ripoll Vidal/Alamy

2025 was in many ways a year of upheaval, from political turnovers and trade wars to energy tensions and the meteoric rise of AI.

Amid this turmoil, some countries deprioritized climate action, slowing momentum at a time when we urgently need to pick up the pace. The evidence is all around us in the form of blistering heat, deadly floods and rampant wildfires.

But that's not the whole story.

While countries like the U.S. are stepping back, others are taking up the mantle of climate leadership. We're seeing a solar revolution in Pakistan. Electric vehicle uptake is growing globally, with EV sales outpacing gas-powered cars in places like Norway and Sweden. Nature-based solutions are taking off across Africa. And at the UN climate summit in November, leaders agreed to triple the amount of money flowing to climate adaptation in developing countries.

While the headwinds facing the green transition should not be understated, there's also growing evidence that climate action is one of the best ways to improve people's lives.

WRI was here through the ups, downs and everything in between. Our editors selected what we believe to be some of our most important stories from the year. Through these articles, our experts **unpack the latest climate science**, **analyze emerging trends** and **shed light on promising solutions**.



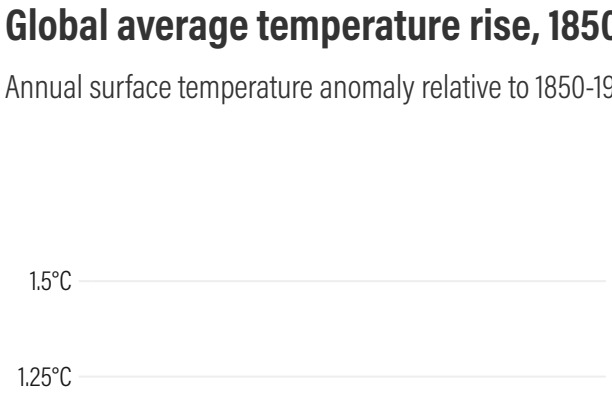
Workers install solar panels in Bahawalpur, Pakistan. The country has seen a rapid and unexpected clean energy boom in recent years. Photo by Xinhua/Alamy

Our Changing Planet

Extreme weather upended communities around the globe in 2025, from devastating wildfires in Los Angeles to severe flooding in southern Asia. Yet the broader changes driving these events aren't always as visible.

World's Warming Target in Peril

Data released in 2025 underscored just how close we are to surpassing the world's 1.5 degree C warming threshold, a target scientists say is necessary for keeping some of the worst climate impacts at bay. **Learn more →**



Source: State of the Global Climate 2024.

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Forests' Carbon Sink Is Shrinking

WRI research found that forests' absorbed far less carbon than usual in 2023 and 2024, a worrying sign for their ability to curb climate change. **Learn more →**

Extreme Heat Is Reshaping Urban Life

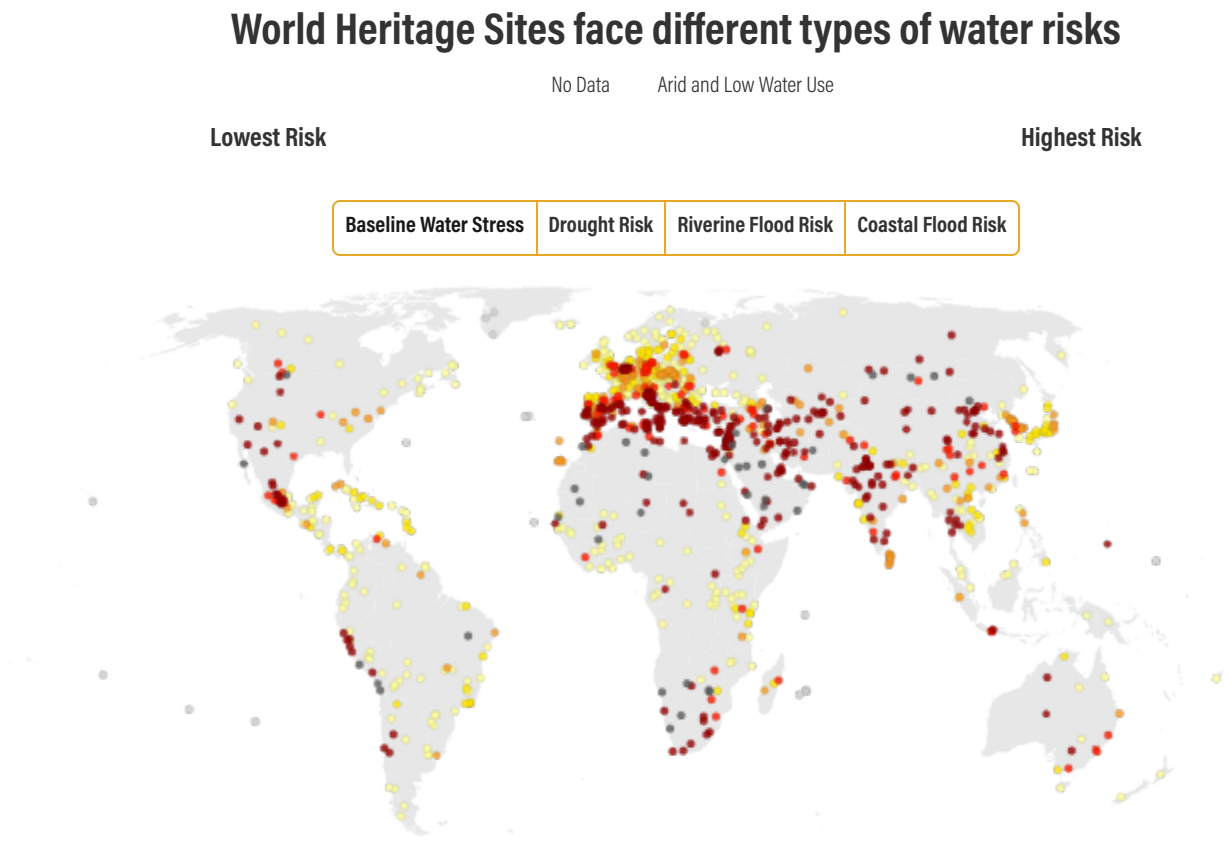
Extreme heat is no longer rare or seasonal. It's a growing pressure that's undermining jobs, transportation and our own health. Europe alone saw thousands of heat-related deaths this year, exacerbated by low access to air conditioning. **Learn more →**

Fires Ravage Tropical Forests

New data confirmed: Forest fires *are* getting worse, burning twice as much forest today as they did 20 years ago. Even historically wet places like tropical rainforests are feeling the effects. **Learn more →**

Cherished Destinations Face Growing Water Risks

From Machu Picchu to the Taj Mahal, WRI research found that most UNESCO World Heritage Sites now face severe water risks such as droughts and floods. Cultural value isn't the only thing at stake. **Learn more →**



Source: WRI Aqueduct/ UNESCO analysis of 1,172 terrestrial UNESCO sites as of March 20th 2025.
Notes: Marine sites were not included in the analysis. Severe drought risk labels are slightly different from the other indicators ("Extremely High" is called "High", and "High" is called "Medium-High"). Sites with large areas or multiple locations are designated on the map by their central point, however the analysis accounts for the water risk to its specific boundaries.

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New Global Realities

New political regimes, changing geopolitics and technological advancements are reshaping the world. These shifts have serious implications for how — and how quickly — we tackle climate and development challenges.

Recent Setbacks Won't Derail the Green Transition

Climate action saw serious setbacks this year, from policy reversals in the U.S. to cuts in international aid. Yet there's reason to believe these hurdles won't halt the great green transition already underway. **Learn more →**

AI Offers Promise and Peril for the Planet

Some see AI's rapid ascent as a solution to thorny climate challenges. Others, as a resource drain that will only compound environmental harms. The truth lies somewhere in the middle. **Learn more →**



The rapid, AI-driven expansion of large data centers like this one in Phoenix, Ariz. has serious implications for energy, water and land use. Photo by Aerovista Luchtfotografie/Shutterstock

The Critical Mineral Conundrum, Explained

Demand for critical minerals like lithium, copper and cobalt could more than double by 2030, largely for clean energy and electric vehicles. While these technologies are central

to a low-carbon future, a surge in new mineral mining could also pose risks for people and nature if not managed properly. **Learn more →**

What's Behind Rising Energy Prices?

U.S. electricity prices are up almost 30% on average since 2010 and still climbing. Common theories about what's behind this rise — data centers? growing demand? wind and solar? — mask a more complex story. **Learn more →**

Countries Deliver Lackluster Climate Plans

All countries were due to submit new national climate commitments this year. Many are falling short of the ambition needed. And collectively, they're far off track from holding temperature rise to 1.5 degrees C. **Learn more →**

Accelerating Solutions

We already know much about what's needed to tackle the climate crisis from the countries, communities and companies making strong headway. From 2025 onward, the world's big task is to accelerate the pace of change.

10 Years After the Paris Agreement, What's Next?

On the Paris Agreement's 10th anniversary, WRI President and CEO Ani Dasgupta reflected on what the landmark climate treaty achieved in its first decade — and how to keep its vision alive. **Learn more →**

The State of Climate Action in 2025

The latest State of Climate Action report found that not one indicator of global climate action is moving fast enough. But importantly, it also charts a path to get on track. **Learn more →**



The Compelling Investment Case for Climate Adaptation

WRI research finds that every $1 spent on climate resilience can generate up to $10.50 in economic, social and environmental benefits over the next 10 years, turning traditional views of climate adaptation on their head. **Learn more →**

6 Ways to Accelerate World's Energy Transition

The world *is* moving toward a clean energy future, but too slowly. Unlocking progress will take six things, from modernizing power grids to overcoming local pushback.

Learn more →

Reviving Land to Boost Economies

From Ghana's cocoa belt to the "Cradle of Mankind" in Kenya's Greater Rift Valley, an important change is taking root. Farmers are proving that it's possible to restore degraded lands while boosting incomes in the process. **Learn more →**



Goshen Global Vision and WRI's Restore Local initiative work with local farmers to restore land in Ghana through beekeeping, agroforestry and other measures. Photo by Sena Affadu/WRI

*Explore more stories at the intersection of people, nature and climate on **Insights**.*

Featured WRI Experts:

Sarah Parsons - Senior Editor

Relevant Work

2024 in Review: Our Biggest Stories on People, Nature and the Climate

Insights DECEMBER 19, 2024

FINANCE

Climate Finance Is a Top Story to Watch in 2025

Insights JANUARY 30, 2025

CLIMATE

4 Climate Stories that Will Define 2024

Insights JANUARY 23, 2024

ENERGY

The State of Clean Energy, in 10 Charts

Insights DECEMBER 10, 2025